Knowledge organiser (SUMMIT) — Recording an exhibition: three visual moments

Pathway: SUMMIT · Week 6 Part 1 · Big question: How do we capture rapid observational sketches, spatial notes, and lighting analyses from curated artworks?

Core studio focus

Family: Identity and studio log

Big question: How do we capture rapid observational sketches, spatial notes, and lighting analyses from curated artworks?

• Use your Week 5 Gallery inquiry Sheet to record three distinct visual moments from the curated exhibition collection.

• Capture (1) a spatial & lighting sightline sketch, (2) a 5-value compositional tonal map, and (3) a close-up material execution study.

• Annotate your field sketches with live analytical observations on scale, texture, and audience mood.

Essential vocabulary

• field sketch: A rapid, observant drawing made directly in front of an artwork to capture structure, light, and mark-making.

• visual moment: A specific focal aspect of an exhibition (how a piece is lit, how two works contrast, or how a joint is made).

• shorthand mark: Fast, expressive hatching or stippling that records surface texture in seconds.

• curatorial framing: How plinths, borders, lighting angles, and wall space direct the viewer's response.

• primary evidence: Your own first-hand sketches and observational notes recorded directly from the artworks.

Three-step studio method

Step 1: Capture moment 1 (Spatial & Lighting sketch): At station A, I sketch the relief panel on its easel, drawing directional arrows for the 25-degree top-left lamp and shading the deep cast shadows.

Step 2: Capture moment 2 (5-Value tonal Map): At station B, I half-close my eyes and block in the five tonal values showing how the bright central motif separates from the dark ground.

Step 3: Capture moment 3 (Surface close-up & Notes): I look closely on a laminated gusset joint, transcribe the embossed rivet texture, and annotate how the patina creates aged weight.